

After you have selected the applications, you can grab some popcorn and sit in front of the screen looking at what happens. You may not understand all or some of it, but then, for a first-timer, it's an experience!

Depending on the speed of your computer and the applications chosen, the install time can vary from 30 minutes to up to three hours. After Linux and the applications are installed, you will be prompted to take the CD (or DVD) out of the drive and reboot.

You will see a screen that allows you to choose from Windows or Linux (this is called the Boot Loader). Select Linux and voila—you have Linux up and running (unless there are some tasks that happen post-reboot, in which case your system will be ready for use by the next reboot). As Linux boots, you'll see a lot of text scrolling by as each service is started, and an “OK” or “Failed” message next to each line. In a few seconds' time you will be prompted for your user ID and password. We suggest *not* logging in as root when you are new to Linux. Log in as a user, so that you will not be allowed to perform critical tasks. Now is the time to just explore and have fun.

2.3 The Root User

Welcome aboard Linux !

First things first—we told you about the root user. So who or what exactly is the “root”?

Linux provides virtually unlimited customisation options which in Windows could be called “system hacking.” Many of the changes the user can make can even result in boot failures! This is especially so because the command line (console) mode contains a large set of commands with even larger set of sub-options. A change in a command option can be the difference between the intended action and a disastrous happening. Therefore, core system modification rights are given only to the root user, who is expected to be well-versed with all he is doing.